

DBT FOR ANGER

Skills to Manage Rage Without Destroying Relationships

Dialectical Behavior Therapy Skills
for Anger Management

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UNDERSTANDING ANGER IN DBT

DBT (Dialectical Behavior Therapy) views anger as a valid emotion that becomes problematic when it leads to destructive behavior.

THE DBT PERSPECTIVE ON ANGER:

- Anger is not 'bad' - it carries information
- The problem is not the emotion but the behavioral response
- You can feel intensely angry AND choose skillful behavior
- Both things are true: your anger is valid AND your actions matter

THE FOUR DBT SKILL MODULES FOR ANGER:

1. MINDFULNESS - Observing anger without being controlled by it
Noticing urges without acting on them
2. DISTRESS TOLERANCE - Surviving anger crises without making things worse (when you can't fix the situation right now)
3. EMOTION REGULATION - Reducing vulnerability to anger and changing unwanted emotional responses
4. INTERPERSONAL EFFECTIVENESS - Expressing anger in ways that maintain relationships and self-respect

WHY ANGER IS ESPECIALLY CHALLENGING:

- Anger feels justified (so we resist changing it)
- Anger provides temporary power/control
- Anger masks vulnerable emotions (hurt, fear, shame)
- Anger creates short-term relief but long-term damage
- Others may reinforce our anger (agree we're 'right')

EMOTION REGULATION MODEL FOR ANGER

Understanding the COMPONENTS of your anger gives you multiple intervention points. Each component can be changed:

VULNERABILITY FACTORS (what makes anger more likely):

- Physical illness or pain
- Sleep deprivation
- Hunger or poor nutrition
- Substance use (alcohol lowers threshold)
- Accumulated stress without relief
- Unresolved emotional pain

My top vulnerability factors: _____

PROMPTING EVENT (what triggers the anger):

- External: something someone does or says
- Internal: a thought, memory, or physical sensation

My common prompting events: _____

INTERPRETATIONS (what you tell yourself about the event):

- 'They did it on purpose'
- 'This is unfair / They should know better'
- 'I'm being disrespected'

My typical interpretations: _____

BODY SENSATIONS: Heat, tension, heart rate, adrenaline

ACTION URGES: Hit, yell, throw, slam, leave, retaliate

EXPRESSIONS: Yelling, sarcasm, silent treatment, aggression

AFTEREFFECTS: Guilt, shame, damaged relationships, consequences

INTERVENTION: You can change ANY component to change the emotion.

OPPOSITE ACTION FOR ANGER

Opposite Action is the #1 DBT skill for anger. When anger urges say DO something destructive, you do the OPPOSITE instead.

WHEN TO USE OPPOSITE ACTION:

- When acting on anger would make things WORSE
- When anger is not justified by the facts
- When anger is justified but acting on it is ineffective

ANGER'S ACTION URGES vs OPPOSITE ACTIONS:

Urge: Attack/criticize --> Opposite: Gently avoid or be kind
Urge: Yell/raise voice --> Opposite: Speak softly and slowly
Urge: Slam/throw things --> Opposite: Relax hands, unclench
Urge: Storm out --> Opposite: Stay (or leave calmly)
Urge: Give silent treat --> Opposite: Communicate directly
Urge: Seek revenge --> Opposite: Let go or problem-solve
Urge: Ruminates/obsess --> Opposite: Distract, do something else

HOW TO DO OPPOSITE ACTION FULLY:

1. Identify the action urge (what does anger want me to do?)
2. Identify the opposite (what would a calm person do?)
3. Do the opposite ALL THE WAY (body, face, words, posture)
4. Repeat until the emotion changes intensity

IMPORTANT: Do this with WILLINGNESS, not white-knuckling.
Opposite action done resentfully doesn't work as well.

MY PRACTICE:

My typical anger urge: _____

My opposite action: _____

TIPP SKILLS FOR RAGE MOMENTS

TIPP is for CRISIS moments when anger is at 8-10/10 and you need to change your body chemistry FAST before you do damage.

T = TEMPERATURE

Dunk your face in ice water for 30 seconds (or hold ice on face)

This triggers the dive reflex and immediately slows heart rate

HOW: Bowl of ice water, lean face in. Or ice pack on eyes/cheeks

SCIENCE: Activates parasympathetic nervous system instantly

I = INTENSE EXERCISE

Do vigorous exercise for 15-20 minutes to burn off adrenaline

Sprint, jump rope, climb stairs, pushups - anything HARD

HOW: Immediately start moving. Don't think, just move.

SCIENCE: Metabolizes stress hormones, releases endorphins

P = PACED BREATHING

Breathe out LONGER than you breathe in

Inhale 4 counts, exhale 6-8 counts. Repeat 10+ times

HOW: Breathe from belly, not chest. Slow way down.

SCIENCE: Activates vagus nerve, reduces fight-or-flight

P = PAIRED MUSCLE RELAXATION

Tense muscles while breathing in, relax while breathing out

Start with fists, then arms, shoulders, face, whole body

HOW: Hold tension 5 sec, release. Notice the contrast.

SCIENCE: Releases physical holding patterns of anger

USE TIPP WHEN: You are about to explode. These are EMERGENCY tools.

Use them BEFORE trying to talk or make decisions.

DEAR MAN WHILE FURIOUS

Interpersonal Effectiveness When Angry

DEAR MAN is the DBT skill for asking for what you want effectively.

Here's how to use it when anger makes you want to DEMAND:

D = DESCRIBE (just the facts, no interpretation)

'When I got home, the dishes were still in the sink.'

NOT: 'You never do anything around here!'

Practice: _____

E = EXPRESS (how you feel, using I-statements)

'I feel frustrated and overwhelmed.'

NOT: 'You make me so angry!'

Practice: _____

A = ASSERT (what you want, specifically)

'I need us to split chores evenly.'

NOT: 'Figure it out!' or 'You should know!'

Practice: _____

R = REINFORCE (why they'd want to help)

'If we share the load, we'll both be less stressed and fight less.'

Practice: _____

M = MINDFUL (stay on topic, don't get derailed)

If they deflect: 'I hear that, and I want to stay on this topic.'

A = APPEAR CONFIDENT (even when shaking inside)

Eye contact, steady voice, upright posture

N = NEGOTIATE (be willing to give to get)

'What would work for both of us?'

MINDFULNESS OF ANGER

Observing Without Acting

Mindfulness means OBSERVING your anger without becoming it.

You are not your anger. Anger is something passing through you.

THE OBSERVE SKILL:

Notice anger as it arises. Watch it like weather:

'I notice a sensation of heat in my chest.'

'I notice the thought that this is unfair.'

'I notice the urge to raise my voice.'

You are the observer, not the anger itself.

THE DESCRIBE SKILL:

Put words on your experience without judgment:

'Anger is here. It feels hot and tight.'

NOT: 'I'm so angry I could explode!' (this escalates)

THE PARTICIPATE SKILL:

Fully feel the anger without adding to it:

- Don't suppress it (makes it worse)
- Don't amplify it (rehearsing why you're right)
- Just let it BE without acting on it

PRACTICE: Next time anger arises, try this:

1. Pause. Don't speak or act for 3 breaths.
2. Name it: 'Anger is here.'
3. Notice where it is in your body: _____
4. Rate it 1-10: ____
5. Watch it. Does it stay the same? Grow? Shrink?
6. Remind yourself: 'I can feel this AND choose my action.'

IMPORTANT: Emotions are like waves. If you don't feed them, they WILL peak and then decrease. Every single time.

DISTRESS TOLERANCE FOR EXPLOSIVE MOMENTS

When anger is at crisis level and you cannot resolve the situation right now, use these skills to SURVIVE without making things worse:

STOP SKILL:

- S - Stop. Freeze. Don't move.
- T - Take a step back (physically or mentally)
- O - Observe what's happening inside and outside you
- P - Proceed mindfully (choose, don't react)

DISTRACTION (ACCEPTS):

- A - Activities (go DO something physical)
- C - Contributing (help someone else, get out of your head)
- C - Comparisons (is this really the worst thing?)
- E - Emotions (watch something funny to change the channel)
- P - Pushing away (mentally put it in a box for later)
- T - Thoughts (count backwards, do math, name states)
- S - Sensations (ice, strong taste, loud music)

SELF-SOOTHE (5 senses):

- Sight: Look at something calming (nature, art)
- Sound: Listen to music, nature sounds, silence
- Smell: Essential oils, fresh air, coffee
- Taste: Mint, chocolate, sour candy, hot tea
- Touch: Soft blanket, pet an animal, warm shower

RADICAL ACCEPTANCE:

'This situation is what it is right now. Fighting reality causes MORE suffering. I can accept AND work to change things.'

ANGER CHAIN ANALYSIS #1

Date: ___/___/___ Anger intensity (1-10): ___

PROMPTING EVENT (What happened? Just the facts):

VULNERABILITY FACTORS (What made me more susceptible?):

☐ Tired ☐ Hungry ☐ Stressed ☐ In pain ☐ Used substances
☐ Already upset about something else ☐ Other: _____

INTERPRETATIONS (What did I tell myself about the event?):

BODY SENSATIONS (What did I feel physically?):

ACTION URGES (What did anger want me to do?):

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID (My behavior):

CONSEQUENCES (What happened as a result?):

Short-term: _____

Long-term: _____

WHAT I COULD HAVE DONE DIFFERENTLY:

Skill I could have used: _____

At what point in the chain: _____

REPAIR NEEDED: ☐ Apology ☐ Amends ☐ Conversation ☐ None

ANGER CHAIN ANALYSIS #2

Date: ___/___/___ Anger intensity (1-10): ___

PROMPTING EVENT (What happened? Just the facts):

VULNERABILITY FACTORS (What made me more susceptible?):

☐ Tired ☐ Hungry ☐ Stressed ☐ In pain ☐ Used substances
☐ Already upset about something else ☐ Other: _____

INTERPRETATIONS (What did I tell myself about the event?):

BODY SENSATIONS (What did I feel physically?):

ACTION URGES (What did anger want me to do?):

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID (My behavior):

CONSEQUENCES (What happened as a result?):

Short-term: _____

Long-term: _____

WHAT I COULD HAVE DONE DIFFERENTLY:

Skill I could have used: _____

At what point in the chain: _____

REPAIR NEEDED: ☐ Apology ☐ Amends ☐ Conversation ☐ None

ANGER CHAIN ANALYSIS #3

Date: ___/___/___ Anger intensity (1-10): ___

PROMPTING EVENT (What happened? Just the facts):

VULNERABILITY FACTORS (What made me more susceptible?):

☐ Tired ☐ Hungry ☐ Stressed ☐ In pain ☐ Used substances
☐ Already upset about something else ☐ Other: _____

INTERPRETATIONS (What did I tell myself about the event?):

BODY SENSATIONS (What did I feel physically?):

ACTION URGES (What did anger want me to do?):

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID (My behavior):

CONSEQUENCES (What happened as a result?):

Short-term: _____

Long-term: _____

WHAT I COULD HAVE DONE DIFFERENTLY:

Skill I could have used: _____

At what point in the chain: _____

REPAIR NEEDED: ☐ Apology ☐ Amends ☐ Conversation ☐ None

ANGER CHAIN ANALYSIS #4

Date: ___/___/___ Anger intensity (1-10): ___

PROMPTING EVENT (What happened? Just the facts):

VULNERABILITY FACTORS (What made me more susceptible?):

☐ Tired ☐ Hungry ☐ Stressed ☐ In pain ☐ Used substances
☐ Already upset about something else ☐ Other: _____

INTERPRETATIONS (What did I tell myself about the event?):

BODY SENSATIONS (What did I feel physically?):

ACTION URGES (What did anger want me to do?):

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID (My behavior):

CONSEQUENCES (What happened as a result?):

Short-term: _____

Long-term: _____

WHAT I COULD HAVE DONE DIFFERENTLY:

Skill I could have used: _____

At what point in the chain: _____

REPAIR NEEDED: ☐ Apology ☐ Amends ☐ Conversation ☐ None

ANGER CHAIN ANALYSIS #5

Date: ___/___/___ Anger intensity (1-10): ___

PROMPTING EVENT (What happened? Just the facts):

VULNERABILITY FACTORS (What made me more susceptible?):

☐ Tired ☐ Hungry ☐ Stressed ☐ In pain ☐ Used substances
☐ Already upset about something else ☐ Other: _____

INTERPRETATIONS (What did I tell myself about the event?):

BODY SENSATIONS (What did I feel physically?):

ACTION URGES (What did anger want me to do?):

WHAT I ACTUALLY DID (My behavior):

CONSEQUENCES (What happened as a result?):

Short-term: _____

Long-term: _____

WHAT I COULD HAVE DONE DIFFERENTLY:

Skill I could have used: _____

At what point in the chain: _____

REPAIR NEEDED: ☐ Apology ☐ Amends ☐ Conversation ☐ None

BUILDING MASTERY

Reduce Your Anger Baseline Through Competence

Building Mastery means doing things that make you feel competent and in control. This reduces baseline anger and frustration.

WHY IT WORKS: Much anger comes from feeling powerless or inadequate. When you regularly accomplish things, your threshold for anger rises.

MASTERY ACTIVITIES (choose ones slightly challenging but doable):

- ☐ Exercise goals (building strength, endurance, skill)
- ☐ Learning something new (language, instrument, skill)
- ☐ Completing tasks you've been avoiding
- ☐ Work/career development (courses, certifications)
- ☐ Creative projects (writing, art, building)
- ☐ Relationship skills (having hard conversations well)
- ☐ Home improvement (fixing, organizing, creating)

MY WEEKLY MASTERY PLAN:

Monday: _____
Tuesday: _____
Wednesday: _____
Thursday: _____
Friday: _____
Saturday: _____
Sunday: _____

KEY: Activities should be **SLIGHTLY** challenging. Too easy = no mastery feeling. Too hard = frustration (more anger). Find the sweet spot.

ACCUMULATING POSITIVE EMOTIONS

If your life is all stress and obligation, anger becomes your default emotion. You NEED positive experiences to balance it.

SHORT-TERM: Build pleasant events into EVERY day
(Even 5-10 minutes counts. Non-negotiable daily.)

My pleasant activities list (things that genuinely feel good):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____

LONG-TERM: Build a life worth living

What values do I want to live by? _____

What goals align with my values? _____

One step I can take this week: _____

MINDFULNESS OF POSITIVE EMOTIONS:

When something good happens, NOTICE it. Don't minimize it.

Don't think about when it will end. Just be in it fully.

My daily pleasant event this week: _____

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 1

Day	Anger(0-5)	Urge(0-5)	Acted on?	Skill Used	Effective?
Mon	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Tue	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Wed	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Thu	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Fri	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sat	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sun	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N

SKILLS PRACTICED THIS WEEK:

- ☐ Opposite Action
- ☐ TIPP
- ☐ Mindfulness
- ☐ DEAR MAN
- ☐ Distress Tolerance
- ☐ Chain Analysis
- ☐ Building Mastery

Biggest anger trigger this week: _____

Best skill use this week: _____

What I want to improve next week: _____

NOTES:

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 2

Day	Anger(0-5)	Urge(0-5)	Acted on?	Skill Used	Effective?
Mon	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Tue	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Wed	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Thu	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Fri	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sat	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sun	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N

SKILLS PRACTICED THIS WEEK:

- ☐ Opposite Action
- ☐ TIPP
- ☐ Mindfulness
- ☐ DEAR MAN
- ☐ Distress Tolerance
- ☐ Chain Analysis
- ☐ Building Mastery

Biggest anger trigger this week: _____

Best skill use this week: _____

What I want to improve next week: _____

NOTES:

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 3

Day	Anger(0-5)	Urge(0-5)	Acted on?	Skill Used	Effective?
Mon	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Tue	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Wed	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Thu	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Fri	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sat	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sun	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N

SKILLS PRACTICED THIS WEEK:

- ☐ Opposite Action
- ☐ TIPP
- ☐ Mindfulness
- ☐ DEAR MAN
- ☐ Distress Tolerance
- ☐ Chain Analysis
- ☐ Building Mastery

Biggest anger trigger this week: _____

Best skill use this week: _____

What I want to improve next week: _____

NOTES:

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 4

Day	Anger(0-5)	Urge(0-5)	Acted on?	Skill Used	Effective?
Mon	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Tue	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Wed	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Thu	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Fri	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sat	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sun	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N

SKILLS PRACTICED THIS WEEK:

- ☐ Opposite Action
- ☐ TIPP
- ☐ Mindfulness
- ☐ DEAR MAN
- ☐ Distress Tolerance
- ☐ Chain Analysis
- ☐ Building Mastery

Biggest anger trigger this week: _____

Best skill use this week: _____

What I want to improve next week: _____

NOTES:

WEEKLY DIARY CARD - WEEK 5

Day	Anger(0-5)	Urge(0-5)	Acted on?	Skill Used	Effective?
Mon	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Tue	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Wed	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Thu	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Fri	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sat	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N
Sun	___	___	Y / N	_____	Y / N

SKILLS PRACTICED THIS WEEK:

- ☐ Opposite Action
- ☐ TIPP
- ☐ Mindfulness
- ☐ DEAR MAN
- ☐ Distress Tolerance
- ☐ Chain Analysis
- ☐ Building Mastery

Biggest anger trigger this week: _____

Best skill use this week: _____

What I want to improve next week: _____

NOTES:

MY ANGER CRISIS PLAN

When my anger reaches 8/10 or higher, I will follow this plan:

STEP 1: STOP (Do not speak. Do not act. Freeze.)

STEP 2: USE TIPP (circle which one I'll try first):

Temperature / Intense Exercise / Paced Breathing / Muscle Relax

STEP 3: REMOVE MYSELF IF POSSIBLE

I will go to: _____

I will say: 'I need [time] to calm down. I'll be back.'

STEP 4: AFTER 20 MINUTES, RE-ASSESS

Current anger level: ____/10

Am I ready to re-engage? [] Yes [] Need more time

STEP 5: IF STILL HIGH, CALL MY SUPPORT:

Person 1: _____ Phone: _____

Person 2: _____ Phone: _____

STEP 6: WHEN CALM, DO A CHAIN ANALYSIS (pages 10-14)

RED FLAGS (situations where I need to LEAVE immediately):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

MY COMMITMENT:

I commit to using this plan before I act on anger.

Even if I fail sometimes, I will try again every time.

Signed: _____ Date: ____/____/____